

Legislator: Reverend Raphael Warnock

Bill: S.5628 - State Department Disability Policy and Accommodations Act

[Text - S.5628 - 118th Congress \(2023-2024\): State Department Disability Policy and Accommodations Act | Congress.gov | Library of Congress](#)

Speech:

Mr. President,

Before I begin my formal remarks, I want to inform you that I am guided by a commitment towards civil rights and in my work with civil rights, I have seen how exclusion negatively impacts not only individuals, but entire communities. Due to this, I have dedicated myself to making sure that every human being receives dignity and justice in all aspects of their lives.

With this knowledge, I rise today to speak in support without objection of S. 5628, the State Department Disability Policy and Accommodations Act, and to announce my intention to vote in favor of its passage.

When I asked myself about what groups are seen and what groups are overlooked, I could not ignore that there are more than one billion people around the world living with disabilities that are often pushed into the margins of society. These individuals face barriers to education, employment, health care, and life in general. As I think about these individuals, I consider this legislation to be both necessary and just.

The intended goal of this bill is clear. It seeks to ensure that the inclusion of the disabled is not ignored in American foreign policy. It requires the State Department to create a formal strategy that works to integrate disability rights into foreign assistance, diplomacy, and humanitarian

work. This will also create an Office of International Disability Rights that will be led by an Ambassador-at-Large. This office will guide these efforts and ensure accountability. In addition, this will call for training, accessibility, and a strong commitment to disability inclusion across all programs.

This bill will benefit people with disabilities around the world, especially those in developing countries, as it will create more inclusive policies and programs. It will require the Department of State, United States Agency for International Development, and other federal agencies to work together in order to pass these measures. Nongovernmental organizations, advocates, and international partners will also have more opportunities to have a role in advancing disability rights. This will even help our diplomatic missions as they will stand out for their accessibility and inclusion.

Mr. President, I have also considered what this legislation could do, both the good it may bring and the challenges it may create.

On the positive side, it will strengthen human rights and ensure the dignity of disabled individuals who have been marginalized. This will promote economic growth as it points out how excluding the disabled is not only morally unjust but also results in a loss of productivity and opportunity.

This bill strengthens our democracy, which calls for all citizens to participate, as well as reinforces America's leadership as it will be announcing to the world that America aligns itself with civil rights, which we have prided ourselves with fighting for, have we not?

Now, that is not to say that this bill will not require effort on our parts. It will require agencies to coordinate with each other, as well as improving the data collection and requiring attention

during its implementation. Through this program, we will have to be accountable and follow through on the commitments we make as justice has never been easy to achieve. It requires dedication and persistence.

But that is okay, because the difficulty of the work does not erase the necessity of it. If anything, it reminds us why the work needs to be done.

So today, Mr. President, I stand in support of this legislation.

I stand for those who have too often been unseen and have gone unheard.

I stand for a world in which inclusion is not an exception but is expected.

Mr. President, I will vote yes on the State Department Disability Policy and Accommodations Act, because our commitment to civil rights and justice must include every person, in every place, or else it is meaningless.

Mr. President, I yield the floor.